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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

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Section Title(S)

TERMS OF KINSHIP AND CORRESPONDING PATTERNS OF BEHAVIOUR AMONG THE THONGA

A woman honours and respects her father- and mother-in-law more than a man his wife's parents. The reason for this can easily be understood, for, concerning the father-in-law, the pattern is the same as for Class II, being the reciprocal of the behaviour of a man towards his daughter-in-law. As regards the mother-in-law, the woman is her servant until she has given birth to a child, as, during the first year, the newly married pair live with the parents of the husband.

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Reciprocally also, a woman will avoid her husband's elder brothers, and joke (*bungunya*) with his younger brothers.

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A man's wife and his sister are in a special relation. They are *muharibo* one to the other. This term used in the Transvaal comes from the Sotho. In Portuguese East Africa it is replaced by *nhombe*. The behaviour is one of friendship.

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We have seen that if a girl gets into trouble, especially as regards sexual matters, she will first seek advice from or make a confession to her paternal aunt or *hahane*. If the *hahane* is not available, she will apply in order of precedence, first to her *kokwana* (*malume's* wife) or her *kokwana* (grandmother), and if these are not to be found she will go to a younger sister of her mother (who is a *mamana*, a mother). It is the *hahane* or these substitutes who will announce the news to the mother of the girl.

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I conclude these incomplete observations on a subject which needs to be studied more extensively with one remark.

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Theoretical Orientation

It has been attempted to explain the special position of the *malume* and of the *hahane* by the following considerations: There is one pattern of behaviour extended to the whole sib of the mother or to the sib of the father. The *malume* represents the sib of the mother and impersonates affectionate and lenient feelings inspired by the mother, whilst the *hahane* personifies the paternal sib and the more stern and respectful sentiments inspired by the father⁽²²⁾.

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There may be some truth in this theory. However, it does not explain the following facts:—

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Theoretical Orientation

(1) Although the *hahane* is often called by the Thonga a "female father," a more careful study of the pattern shows that it allows a great familiarity, and bears no trace of the inhibitions caused by  348 the father's presence. A boy or a girl in difficulties will ask help from their *hahane* rather than from anyone else, even their *malume*.

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(2) Why should the paternal aunt have more influence on the child's father than the father's brothers (even the elder brothers)? And why should she make sacrifices for her nephew rather than her brothers, or even the father of the child?

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(3) Similarly, why should the *malume* embody better the affective qualities of the mother's family than the mother's sisters?

(22) Vide "The Mother's Brother in S. Africa," by Professor Radcliffe Brown, *South African Journal of Science*, 1925.

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